

Researchers: Female Family Ties Important to Social Networks

A recent study suggests that female family ties were central to social networks in ancient Celtic society before the Roman invasion.

Genetic evidence from a late Iron Age cemetery in Britain shows that women were closely related. At the same time, unrelated men were more likely to come into the community from other places, likely after marriage.

This photo provided by Bournemouth University in January 2025 shows the Durotriges tribe project dig in Dorset, southwest England. (Bournemouth University via AP)

For the study, researchers examined ancient DNA from 57 burial places in Dorset in southwestern England. People used the cemetery from around 2100 years ago to around 1800 years ago.

The results showed that two-thirds of the individuals descended from a single maternal lineage.

Lara Cassidy of Trinity College Dublin was one of the study's co-writers. Cassidy suggested to the Associated Press (AP) that the results were surprising, or in her words, "jaw-dropping."

She said that such a finding had "never been observed before in European prehistory."

The study appeared recently in the scientific publication Nature.

The research suggests that women stayed in the same circles throughout life. They kept social networks and likely inherited or managed land and property.

Cassidy told the AP that the findings suggest, "it's your husband who is coming in as a relative stranger, dependent on a wife's family for land and livelihood."

Such a way of living is called matrilocality. The researchers said it is historically rare.

Guido Gneccchi-Ruscione is with the Max Planck Institute in Germany. Gneccchi-Ruscione was not part of the study.

He said researchers studying burial places in Britain and Europe have only discovered the opposite behavior. He said in those communities, women left their homes and families to join their husband's family group.

He said such a way of living, known as patrilocality, has been observed in other ancient time periods. These include the Neolithic period which started more than 10,000 years ago to the early Medieval period more than 1000 years in the past.

This photo provided by Bournemouth University in January 2025 shows a decorated bone comb from an Iron Age Celtic cemetery as part of the Durotriges tribe project dig in Dorset, southwest England. (Bournemouth University via AP)

Cassidy said in studies of pre-industrial societies from around 220 years ago to the present, researchers found that men join their wives' extended family households only eight percent of the time.

But researchers already knew there was something special about the role of women in Iron Age Britain. A group of tribes with closely related languages and art that is often described as Celtic lived in England before the Roman invasion about 2000 years ago.

Valuable objects have been found buried with Celtic women. Roman writers, including Julius Caesar, wrote with disrespect about their relative independence and fighting abilities.

The network of strong female family connections that the researchers found does not necessarily mean that women also held official positions of political power.

Study co-writer Miles Russell of Bournemouth University in England researches ancient societies. He said the findings do suggest that women had some control of land and property and strong social support. Such a situation made Britain's Celtic society more "egalitarian" than the Roman world, Russell said.

I'm John Russell.

Christina Larson reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

cemetery - n. สุสาน, ป่าช้า

descended from - v. (วลี) มีเชื้อสายมาจาก, สืบเชื้อสายมาจากบรรพบุรุษ

maternal - adj. เกี่ยวกับมารดา, เกี่ยวกับฝ่ายแม่

lineage - n. วงศ์ตระกูล, เชื้อสาย

inherit - v. สืบทอด (ทรัพย์สิน), ได้รับมรดก

manage - v. จัดการ, ดูแล

extended family - n. ครอบครัวขยาย (กลุ่มคนจำนวนมากที่เกี่ยวข้องกันทางสายเลือดหรือการแต่งงานที่นับว่าเป็นครอบครัวใหญ่)

egalitarian - adj. ซึ่งมุ่งเน้นความเท่าเทียมกันของทุกคนในสังคม

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What was the central finding of the recent study regarding ancient Celtic society?

- Men held all political power.
- Female family ties were important to social networks.
- The society was entirely matriarchal.
- Romans heavily influenced their social structure.

2. What did the genetic evidence from the Iron Age cemetery reveal about the men in the community?

- They were mostly closely related to each other.
- They often came from other places, possibly after marriage.
- They were primarily farmers.
- They had strong political leadership roles.

3. From what specific material did researchers examine ancient DNA for this study?

- Ancient texts
- Ceramic artifacts
- Burial places
- Animal bones

4. What proportion of individuals in the study were found to have descended from a single maternal lineage?

- One-quarter
- Half
- Two-thirds
- All of them

5. How did Lara Cassidy describe the study's results?

- Predictable
- Jaw-dropping
- Insignificant
- Controversial

6. What made the study's finding unique in the context of European prehistory, according to Lara Cassidy?

- It confirmed existing theories.

It challenged Roman historical accounts.

It had never been observed before.

It provided evidence of advanced technology.

7. In which scientific publication did the study recently appear?

Science Daily

National Geographic

Nature

Archaeology Today

8. Based on the research, what roles did women likely play in ancient Celtic society?

They were solely responsible for raising children.

They primarily engaged in trade with other communities.

They maintained social networks and managed land/property.

They held exclusive rights to religious rituals.

9. What did Lara Cassidy's statement imply about husbands in this ancient society?

They were the primary landowners.

They were often strangers dependent on their wife's family.

They had complete autonomy in marriage.

They usually brought wealth into the family.

10. What term is used to describe a way of living where a husband joins his wife's family, and how rare is it considered?

Patrilocality; very common

Matrilocality; historically rare

Virilocality; increasingly common

Uxorilocality; historically widespread

11. What was Guido Gnechi-Ruscione's relationship to the study?

He was the lead researcher.

He was a co-writer of the study.

He was a critic of the findings.

He was not part of the study.

12. What kind of behavior did Guido Gnechi-Ruscione say researchers typically found in other burial studies in Britain and Europe?

Men joining their wives' families.

Women leaving their homes to join their husbands' families.

Both men and women staying in their birth communities.

Communities where family ties were irrelevant.

13. The common practice where women leave their families to join their husband's group is known as:

Matrilocality

Neolocality

Patrilocality

Avunculocality

14. According to Cassidy, how often did men join their wives' extended family households in pre-industrial societies from around 220 years ago to the present?

Over 50 percent of the time.

Exactly 25 percent of the time.

Only eight percent of the time.

Almost never.

15. According to Miles Russell, what did the findings suggest about the Celtic society in Britain compared to the Roman world?

It was more militaristic.

It was less focused on land ownership.

It was more egalitarian.

It had a stronger central government.